



B. VELANKANNI RAJ

changed for the better. There was one incident at the 1985 World Indoor Games in Paris. From India, only high jumper N. Annavi and I were selected. The climate was very cold. I was put up in a ladies hostel while Annavi stayed far away from me. I used to train alone. It was safe but not easy at all.

After I got married to swimmer Wilson Cherian in 1988, I used to go with him. Sometimes, he was at the

National camp with me. After marriage and motherhood, I became the National champion and took part in two more Olympic Games in 1992 & '96. I am so happy that javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra won a gold medal in the Tokyo Olympics and is expected to win this time too in Paris. Our relay runners, men and women, are doing well. It all depends on the day. I hope and believe that the Indian athletics contingent does even

better in Paris.

For me, participation at the Games was the ultimate as it is the dream of everyone. But very few get to live that dream and I am one of the very few who has done that. I, as a woman and an athlete, had my share of difficulties and struggles in the journey to achieve the Olympic dreams. But it was all worth the effort in the end.

As told to K. Keerthivasan